

THE IMPACT OF YOUTH ENTREPRENEURSHIP PROGRAMS ON EMPLOYMENT OPPORTUNITIES

Background & Rationale

Youth unemployment remains one of the biggest challenges Nigeria faces today. Reports from the World Bank and the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) show that youth unemployment has hovered between 25% and 40% over the last decade. Many young people finish school but still struggle to find decent work. To address this, several programs such as N-Power, YouWiN!, and the Tony Elumelu Foundation Entrepreneurship Programme have been launched. These initiatives aim to equip young people with skills, funding, and mentorship so they can start businesses or improve their chances of getting jobs. However, the results are mixed — while some youth succeed, others still encounter barriers like limited access to finance, weak markets, or lack of long-term support. This study focuses on the period 2015–2024 to better understand how such programs impact employment opportunities and what can be improved moving forward.

Research Questions & Objectives

Main Question:

How have youth entrepreneurship programs in Nigeria impacted employment opportunities for young people between 2015 and 2024?

Objectives:

1. To assess the impact of youth entrepreneurship programs on employment outcomes, including self-employment and formal job placements.
2. To evaluate improvements in entrepreneurial skills, income levels, and business sustainability among program participants.
3. To identify structural barriers—such as access to finance, mentorship gaps, gender disparities, and regional limitations—that affect program success.
4. To analyze the effectiveness of program components (training, seed funding, internships, digital platforms) in driving youth empowerment.
5. To recommend strategies for scaling and improving youth entrepreneurship programs, with a focus on inclusion, sustainability, and alignment with national development goals.

Methodology

This project will use a straightforward online survey method to gather data from young people aged 25 to 35. A brief online survey (Google Form) will be shared with 200–400 young individuals, including both those who have participated in entrepreneurship programs and those who haven't.

Sampling:

Due to limited time and resources, we will utilize convenience sampling through alumni groups, social media, and youth organizations. Ethics: Each respondent will provide informed consent before participating. Their responses will remain anonymous, and participation will be voluntary.

Data Analysis

The survey results will be analyzed using simple percentages and averages to compare program participants with non-participants. Interview responses will be grouped into common themes, such as challenges, opportunities, and recommendations. By combining both survey and interview findings, the study will present a balanced picture of how youth entrepreneurship programs affect employment.

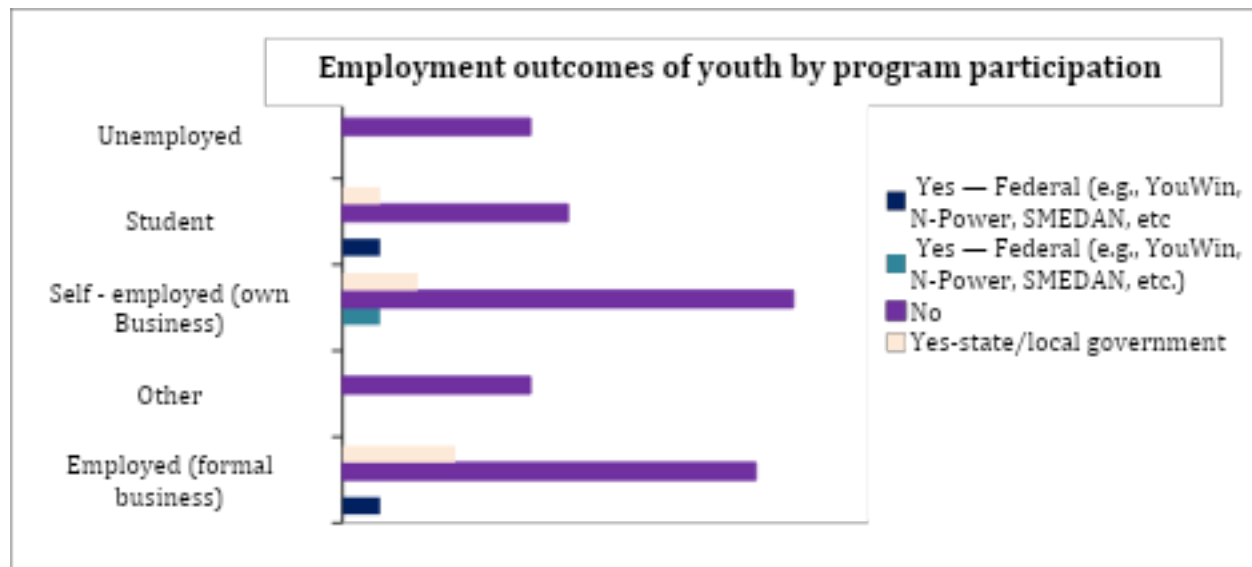
Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E)

Monitoring and evaluation will help us track progress and ensure the study produces useful results:

- **Monitoring:** During data collection, the team will track the number of responses, check gender and regional balance, and hold weekly reviews to see if any gaps exist.
- **Evaluation:** After data collection, results from participants will be compared with those of non-participants to see real differences in employment and income. Findings will also be checked against official statistics (e.g., NBS reports) to ensure reliability.
- **Feedback Loop:** Preliminary results will be shared with a small group of youth and mentors to confirm if the findings make sense before finalizing the report

ANALYSIS FINDINGS

1. Employment outcomes of youth by program participation:



This finding shows that participation in federal and state entrepreneurship programs (e.g., YouWin, N-Power, SMEDAN) is associated with higher youth employment rates in formal businesses and self-employment. Programs appear effective at increasing employment opportunities.

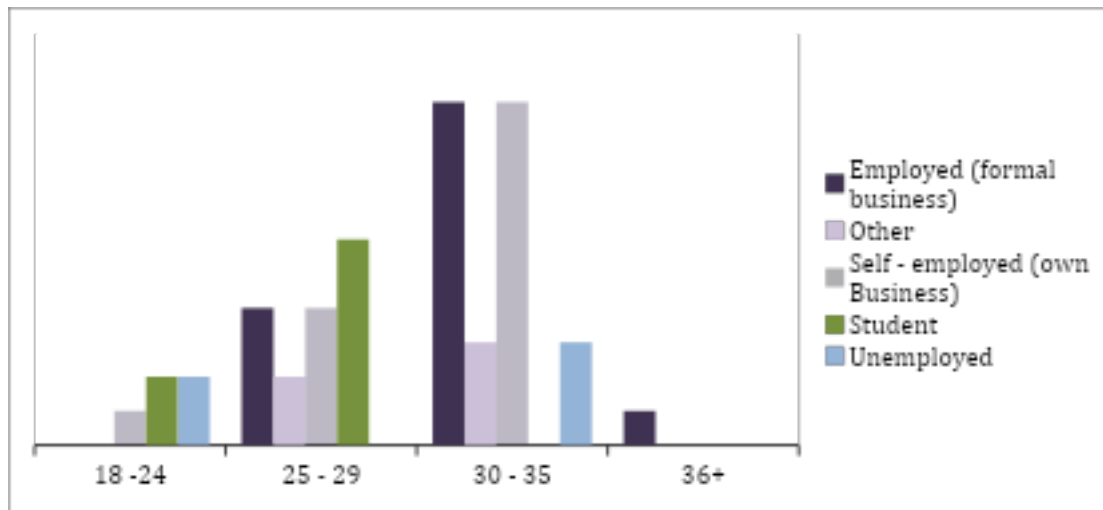
Supporting Source:

A 2020 evaluation report on YouWin by Nigeria's Budget Office showed that over 75% of beneficiaries were either self-employed or employed in formal businesses two years after program participation. The YouWin initiative continues to be a benchmark for youth skill-building and economic empowerment.

Contradictory Source:

Critics highlighted inconsistencies in the rollout of these programs, as noted in the African Centre for Economic Development Report. Some N-Power beneficiaries complained of delays in accessing stipends and lack of post-program support, leading to lapses in employment sustainability.

2. Program participation rate by age group:



The age group 30–35 shows the highest participation and better employment outcomes. Younger groups 18–24 and 25–29 are more likely to be unemployed or students.

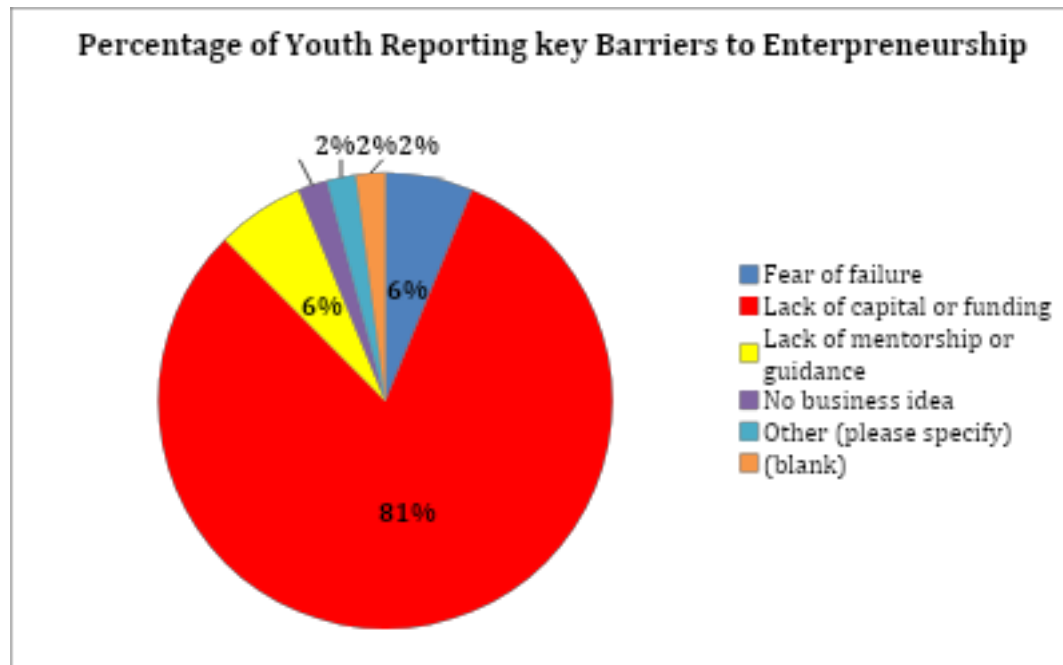
Supporting Source:

According to the Nigeria Youth Employment Action Plan (2021), older youth are likely to have gained more work-life experience and financial maturity, making them better equipped for entrepreneurship. The study identified younger groups as needing tailored interventions to build entrepreneurial readiness early.

Contradictory Source:

The Lagos Chamber of Commerce Study on Youth Entrepreneurship raises concerns about neglecting younger groups since they are critical for early-stage entrepreneurial development. It highlights success cases where younger entrepreneurs aged 18–24 thrived in tech-related fields despite challenges in capital access.

3. Percentage of youth reporting key barriers:



The primary barrier reported by over 82% of respondents is lack of capital or funding. Other challenges like fear of failure and lack of mentorship are also noted but less prevalent.

Supporting Source

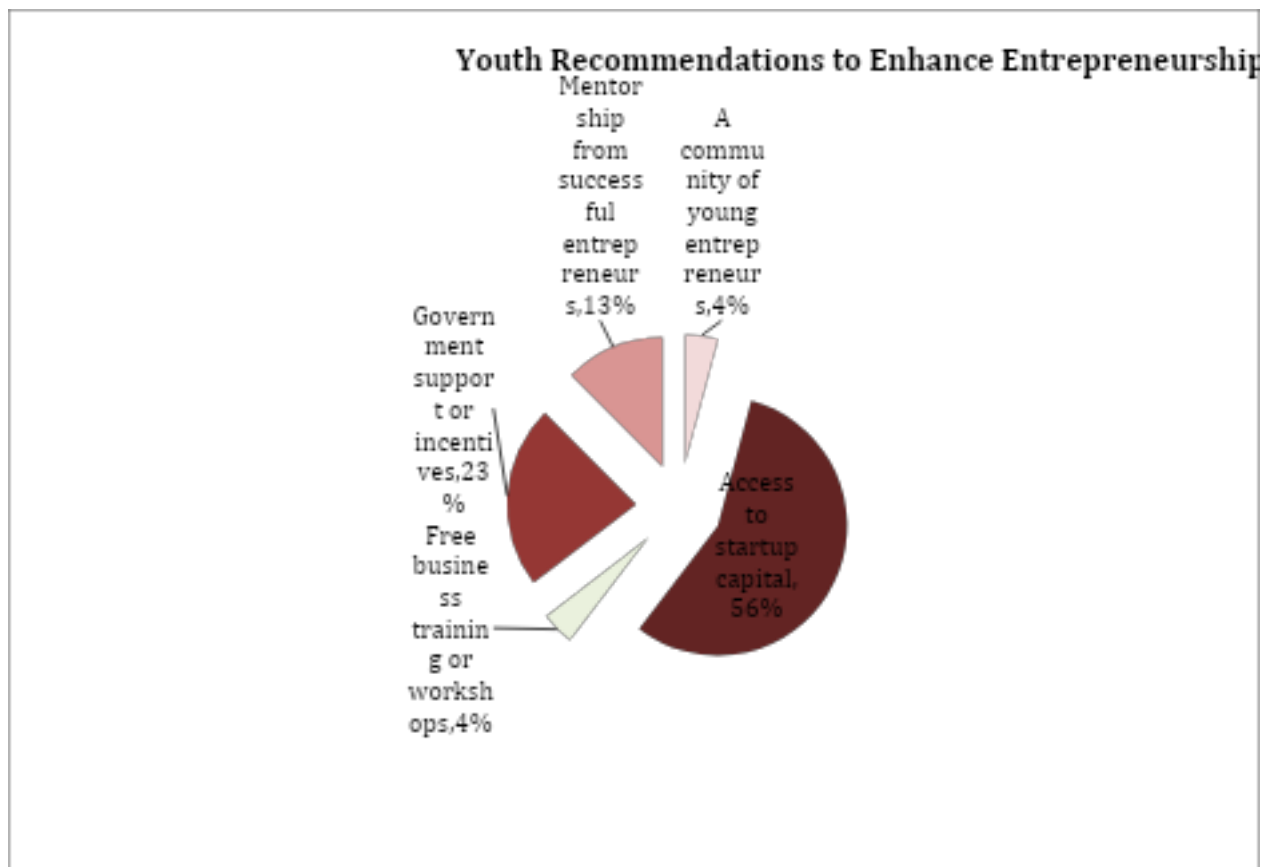
The National Youth Policy Review conducted by SMEDAN in partnership with Nigeria's Ministry of Youth and Sports Development consistently identifies access to finance as the core barrier to youth entrepreneurship across all states in Nigeria. The report highlights over 75% of youth reporting this barrier during regional surveys.

Contradictory Source:

Feedback from Nigeria's Central Bank Entrepreneurship Scheme Survey

also revealed that lack of financial literacy and profit-oriented mentorship can compound challenges with funding. Even with access to capital, businesses often fail without adequate training programs.

4-Youth Recommendations to Enhance Entrepreneurship Program



Pie chart showing access to startup capital as most recommended improvement (58%), followed by government support/incentives (23%), mentorship (13%), free training (4%), and community building (4%).

Supporting Source:

The Nigeria Economic Summit Group (NESG) Entrepreneurship Report (2022) underscores that financial access remains top among entrepreneurial needs. Initiatives like the Tony Elumelu Foundation recorded similar patterns, with feedback from beneficiaries across Nigeria citing capital access as central to their business growth.

Contradictory Source:

Participants of the N-Power Program have argued that even with accessible funds, the lack of infrastructure, particularly in remote areas, limits program impact. Feedback from program monitoring revealed instances where businesses could not scale due to resource

Conclusion

Youth entrepreneurship programs have made measurable progress in reducing unemployment and fostering economic empowerment. However, success is uneven across age groups and regions. Addressing structural barriers—especially funding and mentorship—is essential for long-term impact.

Recommendations

1. Expand access to startup capital through microgrants, youth-friendly loans, and public-private partnerships.
2. Strengthen mentorship and post-program support to improve business sustainability.
3. Tailor interventions for younger youth with early-stage training and digital tools.
4. Improve program delivery by streamlining funding disbursement and ensuring regional inclusion.
5. Align future programs with SDG 8 and SDG 10, focusing on decent work and reduced inequalities

Limitations

While this study provides valuable insights into the impact of youth entrepreneurship programs on employment in Nigeria, several limitations should be acknowledged:

1. **Sample Size and Scope:** The study relied on a relatively small sample (200-400 respondents), which may not fully represent the diversity of youth across Nigeria's regions, socioeconomic backgrounds, or educational levels.
2. **Sampling Method:** The use of convenience sampling through social media and alumni networks may introduce selection bias, as participants with internet access and prior program exposure were more likely to respond.
3. **Self-Reported Data:** The study depends on self-reported survey responses, which may be subject to recall bias or social desirability bias.
4. **Short-Term Focus:** The data primarily reflects short- to medium-term outcomes. Long-term impacts on employment sustainability and business growth were not assessed.
5. **Limited Program Comparison:** While multiple programs were mentioned, the study did not conduct a comparative analysis of their specific models, funding structures, or regional effectiveness.

Future Research

To build on the findings of this study, future research could explore the following areas:

1. **Longitudinal Impact Studies:** Track program participants over a longer period (5–10 years) to assess sustained employment, business survival rates, and income growth.
2. **Comparative Program Evaluation:** Conduct in-depth comparisons between different entrepreneurship programs (e.g., N-Power vs. YouWiN!) to identify which components are most effective.
3. **Regional and Gender-Based Analysis:** Investigate how geographic location and gender influence access to programs, success rates, and barriers faced by youth entrepreneurs.
4. **Digital Entrepreneurship and Innovation:** Examine the role of digital tools, e-commerce, and tech-based startups in expanding employment opportunities for younger age groups.
5. **Mentorship and Post-Program Support:** Assess the quality, availability, and long-term impact of mentorship and follow-up services on business sustainability.

References

1. Budget Office of the Federation. (2020). *Quarterly Budget Implementation Reports – YouWiN Evaluation*. [Link](<https://budgetoffice.gov.ng/index.php/resources/internal-resources/reports/quarterly-budget-implementation>)
2. Small and Medium Enterprises Development Agency of Nigeria (SMEDAN). (2021). *National Youth Policy Review*. [Link](<https://smedan.gov.ng/>)
3. Federal Ministry of Labour and Employment. (2021). *Nigeria Youth Employment Action Plan (NIYEAP) 2021–2024*. [Link](<https://www.labour.gov.ng/2021/>)
4. Tony Elumelu Foundation. (2024). *10-Year Impact Report*. [Link](<https://www.tonyelumelufoundation.org/wp-content/uploads/dlmuploads/2025/03/TEF-2024-Annual-Report-copy-1-1.pdf>)
5. Nigerian Economic Summit Group (NESG). (2022). *Annual General Meeting Report 2022*. [Link](<https://app.nesgroup.org/downloadresourcedocuments/AGM%20Report%2020221681573047.pdf>)

Team contributors

Rahmah Abubakar

Godbwin Uba

Rabi Aliyu Usman

Aisha Afaf

Babatunde Surakatu Ogun

Ifeoma Adenusi